NO. 1
DECEMBER 2026

GUIDED CHILDHOOD NEWS

AGES 6 TO 11
PRINT, READ, DO

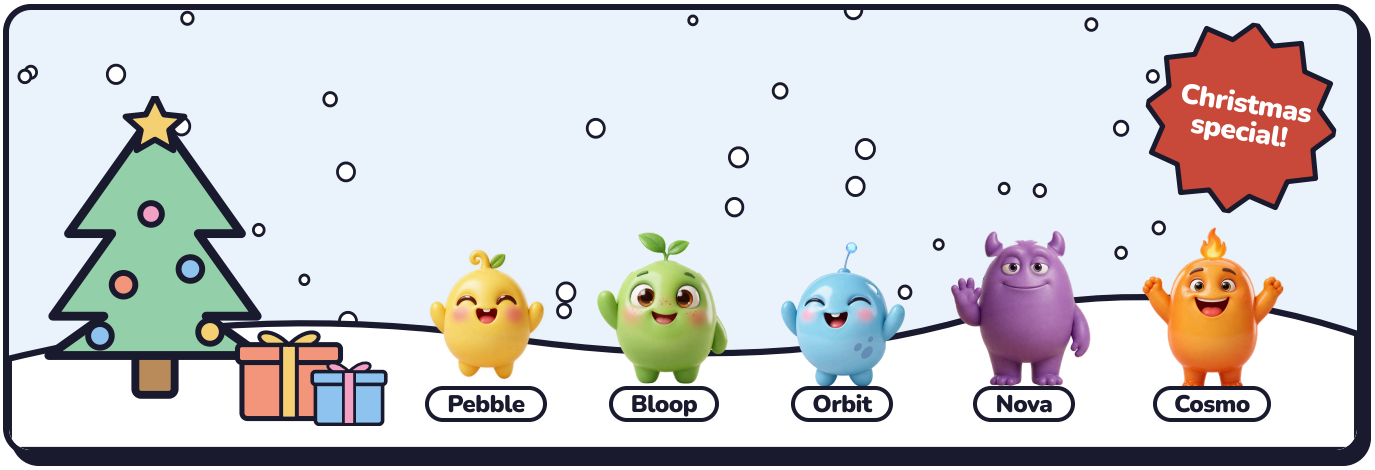
# The Guided Times

Happy news for growing up with screens

CHRISTMAS EDITION · NEW SCREENS UNDER THE TREE · GUIDEDCHILDHOOD.COM

FRONT PAGE NEWS

## Something new under the tree?




The Planet Friends, ready for a cosy Christmas. One Friend for every stage of growing up.

This Christmas, lots of children will unwrap a tablet, a games console or even a first phone. If that is you, hooray! But here is the big news: the best bit is not the box. It is setting it up together.

The Planet Friends have been finding out how families do it, and they have written it all down. Turn to pages 3 and 4 for the Christmas morning plan. Your grown up will want to read it too.

INSIDE TODAY

2 A letter from DiGi
3 The Christmas morning plan
5 The big question
6 The app desk
7 The homework helper
8 The good sites guide
9 Orbit's puzzles
10 Make and do
11 The shop
12 Your Christmas promise



**"The best thing we did was choose where it sleeps before we even switched it on."**

COSMO, THE FRIEND FOR 16 AND UP

SCREEN WEATHER

**Christmas Day: bright and cosy indoors, a strong chance of board games after lunch, and screens resting during dinner.**

A LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

## Hello, and welcome to the very first Guided Times!



I am DiGi, the little gold star who helps families with screens. This is our Christmas edition, so it is all about new screens: how to set one up, how to share it, and how to keep Christmas feeling like Christmas.

Grab a pencil, because every page has something to do. The bits for grown ups are marked with a star, so they know where to look.

**Merry Christmas, DiGi**

# News in brief

FROM AROUND THE PLANET



### Pebble's tablet takes a nap

On Christmas Day the tablet in Pebble's house has a nap after lunch, in a basket by the door. Pebble says the basket is the comfiest place in the house.



### Bloop beats the boss level

Bloop says the hardest level in any game is the moment you press save and stop. Bloop did it with a timer and a snack waiting.



### Orbit spots a fake

A message said Orbit had won a free tablet. Orbit asked a grown up first, and it was pretend. More detective work on page 9.



### Nova's letters go by post

Nova wrote thank you letters by hand this year. Ten minutes each, and Grandad keeps them in a tin.

? DID YOU KNOW?
**The first text message ever sent said Merry Christmas. It went from a computer to a phone on 3 December 1992.**

? DID YOU KNOW?
**The first Christmas cards were printed in London in 1843. People still send them by post every year.**

## Bloop and the big box

THE COMIC STRIP



## The Christmas morning plan

THE BIG FEATURE · PAGES 3 AND 4

# Six things to do together before you press play

A new screen is exciting. These six steps take about half an hour, and they make the first day a good one. Do them with your grown up, in order.

### 1 Give it a name

Every good screen has a name. Ours is called

.....

### 2 Choose where it sleeps

Lots of families charge screens overnight in a shared room, not in bedrooms. Pick the spot together.

### 3 Your grown up does the settings

The family settings and the passcode are a grown up job for now, like the car keys.

### 4 Pick your first three apps

Start with three, chosen together. More can come later, once these are going well.

### 5 Learn stop, close, tell

If something on a screen feels wrong, odd or scary: stop, close it, and tell a grown up. Telling is always the right thing to do.

### 6 Agree the three kinds of time

My time is just mine. Earned time comes from jobs. Protected time has no screens at all, like meals and bedtime.



**Unwrap and say thank you**
Christmas morning

→



**Set it up together**
About half an hour

→



**Play the first game together**
Straight after

→



**Screens nap at lunch**
While the family eats



★ FOR GROWN UPS

The first week sets the pattern. Switch on the built in family settings before the box is handed over (Screen Time on Apple devices, Family Link on Android, the console's own family app), keep the passcode, and play the first game with them.

## ☆ My new screen's ID card

FILL IT IN TOGETHER

Draw your new screen here

It is a: (circle one)

Tablet Console Phone Laptop

Its name is .....

It sleeps in the .....

Its bedtime is .....

If something feels wrong I tell .....

My first three apps

1 .....

2 .....

3 .....

Our protected times: ☐ Meals ☐ Bedtime ☐ Car journeys ☐ Christmas dinner

## Draw your screen in its bed

WHERE WILL IT CHARGE TONIGHT?






My name ..... Grown up .....

## The big question

READ BOTH SIDES, THEN VOTE

# Should screens be switched off on Christmas Day?

Families answer this one differently, and that is fine. Read both sides, then have a family vote.



SIDE ONE

### Yes, switch them off

SAYS NOVA

- ☆ Christmas only comes once a year, and the whole family is here today.
- ☆ Games and videos will still be there on Boxing Day.
- ☆ Board games, walks and making things are better with everyone.



SIDE TWO

### No, keep them on

SAYS COSMO

- ☆ A new game is part of the present. Playing it with my cousins is how we have fun together.
- ☆ Video calls let us see family who live far away.
- ☆ A Christmas film together is a screen too!



**What if screens get their own time slot, like the Christmas film? Everyone knows when, so nobody has to ask.**

ORBIT HAS A MIDDLE IDEA

### Family vote

Everyone writes their name, then ticks one box.

| Names | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Switched off | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| A time slot | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Screens as normal | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

**Our family's Christmas Day screen plan**

☆ **Top tip: decide it on Christmas Eve, not halfway through Christmas afternoon.**

## The app desk

APPS, GAMES AND AGE LABELS

# Read the label before you download

Every game and app has an age label, a bit like a film. In the UK, games show a PEGI number.

3 7 12 16 18

**The number is the age the game is suitable for. It is about what is in the game, not how hard it is.**

### Five questions before you press download

1. What is the age label?
2. Can people I do not know talk to me in it?
3. Does it ask for money inside the game?
4. Does it want my real name, photo or where I live?
5. Have I asked my grown up?

**Most social media apps say you must be 13 or older to have an account.**

### Check an app

App or game .....

Its age label .....

Chat with strangers? Yes No

Money inside it? Yes No

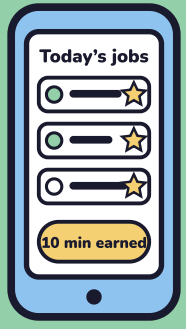
My grown up says Yes Not yet



### Dear DiGi

***"My friends all play a game I am not allowed yet, and I feel left out. What do I do?"*** A question lots of children ask

That feeling is real, and it is fine to say so. Tell your grown up what the game is and why you like it, then read its label together. Ask if there is a way to play it together, or a game your friends like that fits your age. A not yet can become a yes.




★ FOR GROWN UPS

### Our app: Guided Childhood

Guided Childhood is the family app behind this newspaper. Your child gets their own app with no login: jobs earn stars, and stars become screen minutes. Every stage has short lessons on games, social media and AI, stamped in their Digital Passport. Grown ups get one small script for the evening's tricky moment.

**guidedchildhood.com**

## The homework helper

FOR SCHOOL NIGHTS, AND THE HOLIDAYS

# Stuck? Climb the help ladder



5. **Write a note for your teacher: I got stuck on...**
4. **Ask someone at home to listen, not to do it for you.**
3. **Try one small bit, even if it might be wrong.**
2. **Look back in your book for an example.**
1. **Read the question out loud, slowly.**

START AT THE BOTTOM AND CLIMB

### Make a homework spot

- [ ] A clear bit of table
- [ ] A pencil, a rubber, a ruler
- [ ] A glass of water
- [ ] Phones parked in another room
- [ ] A timer for a break



### AI helpers and homework

**Chatbots can explain things, but they can also be wrong, and your teacher wants to see your thinking. Many chatbots are for 13 and over, so only use one with a grown up, and ask it to explain, never to do it for you.**

★ FOR GROWN UPS

### How much homework is normal?

A normal night, reading included, from what UK school homework policies commonly publish. Your school's own policy always wins. If it is often far more, or ends in tears, the teacher is the person to tell.

**Over the holidays, a bedtime story still counts. Reading together is the homework that never stops.**

| | |
|---|---|
| Reception | 5 to 10 minutes |
| Years 1 and 2 | 10 to 20 minutes |
| Years 3 and 4 | 15 to 25 minutes |
| Years 5 and 6 | 20 to 30 minutes |
| Years 7 and 8 | 40 to 60 minutes |
| Years 9 to 13 | 60 to 90 minutes |

## The good sites guide

CHECKED BY ORBIT

# Helpful websites for growing up online



Orbit has checked every one of these. They are free, and none of them needs an account to read.

FOR CHILDREN

bbc.co.uk/bitesize

### BBC Bitesize

Help with every school subject, with short videos and games.

bbc.co.uk/newsround

### Newsround

Real news from around the world, written for children.

thenational.academy

### Oak National Academy

Free lessons that follow what you learn at school.

natgeokids.com/uk

### National Geographic Kids

Animals, science and amazing facts about our planet.

childline.org.uk

### Childline

Free, private help with anything that is worrying you, online or off. Or call 0800 1111.

### Is it a good website?

- ☐ Who made it?
- ☐ Is it for my age?
- ☐ Does it ask for my name or photo?
- ☐ Did a grown up say yes?

★ FOR GROWN UPS

internetmatters.org

### Internet Matters

Step by step guides to the family settings on every device.

saferinternet.org.uk

### UK Safer Internet Centre

Online safety advice for families, and Safer Internet Day each February.

nspcc.org.uk

### NSPCC

Online safety advice, and a helpline for any worried grown up.

commonsensemedia.org

### Common Sense Media

Age reviews of films, games and apps, written by parents and experts.



**Orbit's tip: type the address yourself, from this page, rather than tapping an advert or a link in a message.**

**Our family's favourite website**



ORBIT'S CHRISTMAS PUZZLES

## Real or pretend?

Three messages arrived on Christmas Eve. Circle real or pretend for each one.

**1**

FROM: PRIZE TEAM

**You have WON a free tablet! Tap the link and type your address to claim it.**

Real Pretend

**2**

FROM: GRANDMA

**Thank you for my drawing! It is on my fridge. Love you lots.**

Real Pretend

**3**

FROM: PARCEL DELIVERY

**Your present is stuck. Pay £1.99 now to send it today.**

Real Pretend

## Christmas screen word search

| | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Y | P | D | H | J | T | E | L | L | D |
| B | P | N | F | X | B | P | G | U | V |
| P | P | Z | X | B | P | A | U | S | E |
| T | A | B | L | E | T | C | M | S | Y |
| K | I | N | D | Z | V | H | Y | T | H |
| M | M | V | G | F | M | A | G | A | F |
| M | M | C | F | A | V | R | F | R | S |
| Z | A | S | K | Z | M | G | N | Y | A |
| F | X | S | N | O | W | E | X | Y | F |
| U | N | M | H | P | Y | U | M | H | E |

- ☐ tablet
- ☐ charge
- ☐ pause
- ☐ kind
- ☐ safe
- ☐ ask
- ☐ tell
- ☐ snow
- ☐ game
- ☐ star

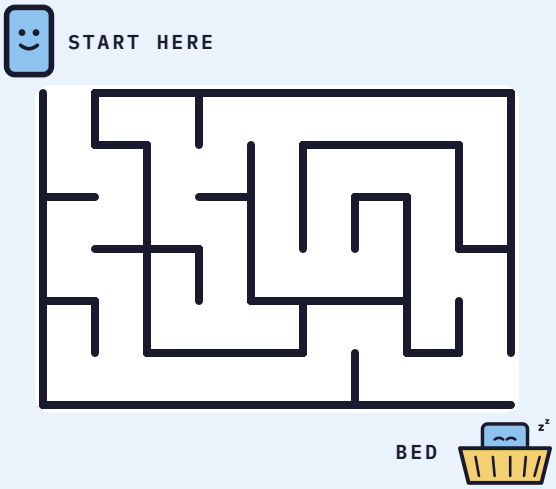
## Crack the code

A is 1, B is 2, C is 3, all the way to Z is 26. What do you do if something online feels wrong?

| | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 19 | 20 | 15 | 16 | | 3 | 12 | 15 | 19 | 5 |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 20 | 5 | 12 | 12 |

## Help Tabby find its bed



**Make and do** SCREEN FREE FUN FOR THE HOLIDAYS

# Boxing Day bingo



Tick a square each time you do one. Four in a row and you win the next pick of the board game!

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Build a den ○ | Play a board game ○ | Go for a frosty walk ○ | Make a paper snowflake ○ |
| Help make lunch ○ | Read a new book ○ | Video call someone far away ○ | Draw for a grandparent ○ |
| Play hide and seek ○ | Do a jigsaw ○ | Have a dance ○ | Bake something ○ |
| Write a thank you letter ○ | Spot a robin ○ | Tidy the wrapping ○ | Teach someone a game ○ |

## Make a sign for the screens' bed

1. Colour both sides.
2. Cut along the solid line.
3. Fold on the dotted line.
4. Stand it by the charging spot.

✂

Awake: playing time

FOLD



Shh! Screens asleep

The shop SMALL ADS

# Small ads from the Guided Childhood shop

Everything here is a print at home pack, made by us and loved by the Planet Friends. Find them all in our Etsy shop.




AGES 4 TO 16 · START HERE

## The Guided Childhood Passport

The fold out passport your child stamps, stage by stage, from first screen to 16.



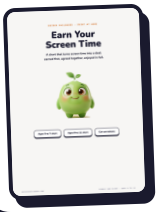
Start here!



AGES 4 AND UP

### The Star Chart

Jobs earn stars and stars become screen minutes. The fridge chart that makes it a deal.




AGES 5 TO 11

### Earn Your Screen Time

Screen tokens to cut out and ending cards, so the end of screen time is no surprise.




AGES 10 TO 12

### The Family Phone Agreement

A first phone deal your child writes with you, rather than rules handed down.




AGES 4 TO 9

### The Calm Down Corner Kit

A calm corner sign, feelings cards and star breathing, set up together on an ordinary day.




AGES 4 TO 11

### The Christmas Screen Free Countdown

24 doors from 1 to 24 December, one Planet Friend activity a day, and a sticker sheet.



CHRISTMAS VISITS

### Screens At Granny's

House rules that travel: a card for the grandparents and a card for your child.

**Every pack ends with its own sticker for the Passport page it belongs to.**

FIND THEM ALL

**etsy.com/shop/GuidedChildhood**

Instant downloads. Print at home as many times as your family needs.



# Our Christmas screen promise

Over Christmas, our screens sleep in the .....

Our protected times are .....

If something online feels wrong, I will .....

One screen free thing we will do together .....

My name ..... Grown up .....

COMING NEXT

**Issue 2, January 2027: The new year screen deal. It arrives in our Etsy shop at the end of December. Tap the heart on our shop to hear first.**

Issue 2



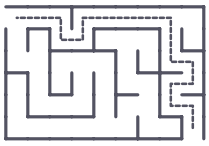
**A free gift from us: the Guided Childhood Starter Pack, at guidedchildhood.com/etsy-bonus**

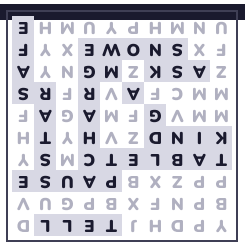
If your family enjoyed this issue, a short review on Etsy helps other families find us. Thank you.

## Colour in Christmas

The tree, the presents and the screens tucked up in bed. Use every crayon you have.





ORBIT'S ANSWERS

1 is pretend: real prizes never need your address from a message.
2 is real: Grandma, and she wants nothing from you.
3 is pretend: ask a grown up before you ever pay for anything.
The code says: stop close tell. Stop, close it, and tell a grown up.